Flourish
LEGAL WELL-BEING

Cheat Sheet: **Dealing with Conflict**

We tend to attribute other people's behavior to the sort of person they are, rather than considering the circumstances affecting their behavior.

Social psychologists call this the **Actor-Observer Bias ("AOB").** It can lead us to react with undue judgment, harshness, or impatience.

To avoid the AOB when encountering conflict or frustrating behavior, try these two steps:

First

Take one slow breath, to calm the nervous system and insert a pause.

- Aim for about five seconds each for the inhale and exhale.
- If circumstances don't permit that, slow your breathing to whatever degree is practical.
- Breathe from the belly, not just from the chest.

Then

Ask yourself one of these questions (whichever works best for you):

- "Do I know everything they're going through?"
- "Haven't I done that same thing myself?"